

ENGLISH LANGUAGE PAPER 4

PART A Group Interaction

Below is an extract from a magazine about Finland's education system:

Finland – the world's best education system

The 2012 global league table, produced by the Economist Intelligence Unit, has found Finland to have the best education system in the world. The rankings combined international test results and data such as graduation rates between 2006 and 2010. Finland has consistently topped the international rankings for education systems. Why is it so successful? Below are some characteristics:

1. Students don't start school until they're 7 years old.
2. No standardized tests until they are 16 years old.
3. Grades are not compulsory until students are in lower secondary.
4. Students of different abilities are taught in the same classroom.
5. No homework because it is assumed that mastery is achieved in the classroom.
6. Education emphasizes "equal opportunity for all". They value equality over excellence.
7. About two-thirds of students in Finland attend college. That's the highest rate in all of Europe.
8. Only the top 10% of school graduates are eligible to become teachers.
9. All teachers are required to have a master's degree, which is fully paid for by the government.
10. Teachers receive more professional development.

Your group is preparing for a discussion topic "Our Education System" for a Critical Thinking class. You may want to talk about:

- the most positive aspects of Finland's education system
- positive aspects of Hong Kong's education system
- which characteristics of Finland's education system would not work in Hong Kong
- anything else you think is important

PART B Individual Response

1. Did you enjoy studying at primary school?
2. Does homework help you to learn better?
3. Is it too late to start school at seven years old?
4. Would you like to study in a school like the ones in Finland?
5. Should students of different abilities be separated into different groups?
6. Do examinations motivate you to study?
7. Would you have learnt more if you had studied in Finland?
8. Do all students in Hong Kong have equal opportunities in education?